entirely to myself on a sunny winter afternoon and sat there thinking about Ibn Batuta and the unpredictable Sultan.

Ibn Batuta grew to fear the volatile Sultan over time. He would eventually get himself assigned to an embassy to China and flee. We are told that, as the embassy made its way south, it was repeatedly attacked by bandits. Ibn Batuta tells us that he was captured and nearly killed before being set free. The fact that even an imperial embassy could not safely travel on a major highway shows us the degree to which the interiors of the country had been plunged into chaos by the Turkic invasions.

After many more adventures, Ibn Batuta did eventually make his way to China. Despite his fame in the Arab world, his adventures are barely remembered in India outside of the world of specialist historians and scholars. His memory is now limited to a mention in a somewhat inane but popular Hindi song about his shoe!

One would have thought that after having built three capitals—Tughlaqabad, Daulatabad and Jahanpanah—the Tughlaq dynasty would have grown tired of building. Not so. Muhammad's successor Feroze Shah Tughlaq was an even more enthusiastic builder. He built many new structures as well as repaired many old ones. He also extended the city northwards by building a fortified palace-complex along the Yamuna called Feroze Shah Kotla. We know that the older Delhis were still inhabited, so it is possible that this was just a royal suburb like Versailles.

The enigmatic ruins of Feroze Shah Kotla are near the busy ITO crossing and just behind the offices of India's leading newspapers. They were repeatedly cannibalized for building material by builders of later Delhis. Nonetheless, the site contains a three-storeyed pavilion topped by the Ashokan pillar that had been carefully brought there by the Sultan. The complex is said to be inhabited by djinns and people, mostly Sufi Muslims, visit the site to light lamps to assuage and petition them. One will see small offerings and walls blackened by the smoke from the lamps. Some of the faithful tie colourful strings to the grill put up by the Archaeological Survey to protect the Ashokan pillar. Thus we have the impossible combination of